The Oliver Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Lyme Regis, Dorset

Dear Oliver,

My name is Mary Anning, and I am writing to you from Lyme Regis, a little town by the sea in Dorset. I am told this letter will travel nearly two hundred years to reach you!

I hunt for fossils. After winter storms, rocks tumble down from the cliffs, and inside them I find the bones of creatures that lived long, long ago. When I was about twelve, I dug out the skeleton of a huge sea reptile called an ichthyosaur. Its name means fish-lizard!

I hear you love dinosaurs. So do I! My ichthyosaurs swam in the sea at the same time as the dinosaurs. On the beach I often find ammonites, which are curly shells turned to stone. I have drawn one for you.

My dog Tray comes fossil hunting with me. He is very patient while I dig.

Your friend from the seashore,

Mary

P.S. If you found a fossil on the beach, what would you hope it was?

REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Mary's letter, for Oliver and a grown-up to read together.

1. Mary Anning (born 1799) was a fossil hunter from Lyme Regis in Dorset, on the coast now called the Jurassic Coast.
2. Around 1811, her brother Joseph found the skull of an ichthyosaur, and Mary, aged about 12, found the rest of the skeleton.
3. Ichthyosaurs were sea reptiles that lived at the same time as the dinosaurs, but they were not dinosaurs themselves.
4. Scientists of her day often didn't give Mary credit for her discoveries. Today she is remembered as one of the greatest fossil hunters.
5. Storytelling: Mary never wrote to children in the future, but she really did have a dog called Tray who came fossil hunting with her.

Write back to Mary!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Mary's next letter will answer you.